CMU-Africa Application Preparation Package

MS Information Technology + Mastercard Foundation Scholars Program, 2027 intake

Version 1.0 DRAFT, 5 November 2026

1. Key facts (evidence class E2; confirm on the live site before submitting)

Item	Requirement
Programme	MS in Information Technology (MSIT), Kigali, Rwanda; a Carnegie Mellon University degree
Intake	Fall only; the Student Induction Program starts in August
Deadlines	Applications opened **1 Oct**. **Early: 15 Dec** (CMU-Africa covers the DET and competency-test fees for first-time applicants). **Final: 15 Jan.** Year inferred as 2026/27; timezone not stated, so submit at least 48 hours early.
Application fee	None
GPA	No cut-off; most admits ≥ 3.0
English	IELTS / TOEFL / **Duolingo English Test (DET)**. Recommended minimums: IELTS 6.5, TOEFL 81 (French page: 87), DET 120. **PTE not listed.** After 15 Dec, a valid score or a planned test date must be included.
Technical test	1-hour online test (analytical, quantitative, programming logic), sent once the application is complete
Essays	**3 short essays, ≤ 300 words each, plus an optional 4th. One video essay.** Exact prompts are visible in the portal: copy them into Section 4 when you open the application.
Documents	CV; transcripts covering ≥ 3/4 of the degree (you have the full transcript); English score
References	**3 recommenders** (contact details; they submit online)

Item	Requirement
Scholarship	Considered **after admission**. Mastercard Foundation criteria: academic talent, commitment to giving back, potential to lead; **financial need / disadvantaged background**; age ≤ 35; African citizenship. Admission does not guarantee the scholarship.
Funding if selected	Tuition and fees, health insurance, travel, basic living, project/entrepreneurship support. African-student tuition 2026–27: USD 16,000.
Integrity	Plagiarism leads to denial. The essays must be your own words; my drafts are a starting structure for you to rewrite in your voice.

2. Timeline to the early deadline (15 Dec 2026)

Date	Task	Owner
5–12 Nov	Request HR experience letters; confirm titles and dates (DR-06, DR-07); choose 3 recommenders and send the briefing pack	**You**
by 10 Nov	Create the portal account (**you**, not me); copy the exact essay prompts into this document	**You**
10–20 Nov	Fill in the Evidence Worksheet; I finalise the CMU-Africa CV and adapt the essays to the real prompts	You → me
20 Nov – 1 Dec	Rewrite the essays in your own voice; two rounds of review	You + me
by 1 Dec	Enter recommender details in the portal (they need 2+ weeks)	**You**
1–10 Dec	Video-essay practice (3 recorded mock takes)	You + me
by 12 Dec	**Submit** (3-day buffer). Then take the DET using CMU-Africa's covered-fee	**You** (I never submit)

Date	Task	Owner
	arrangement (follow the portal's instructions; mechanism unverified)	
After submission	Complete the 1-hour technical test when invited	**You**

Alternative: if the DET has to be taken *before* submitting to count as a score, take it in early December at your own cost (about USD 59–70, E3; confirm on Duolingo's site).

3. Essay strategy

Selection criterion	Which essay shows it	Evidence to use (verified or pending)
Academic talent	Essay A + optional essay	Final-year averages 3.05 / 3.35; A– in Compiler Design, Advanced Programming, Complexity Theory, Final Project ✅
Potential to lead	Essay B	⏳ A real instance from the worksheet (POS rollout coordination, incident lead, training). **No leadership will be invented.**
Commitment to giving back	Essay C	Your work on payments in Ethiopia ✅ (employer verified); ⏳ any community or training role (Dereja co-trainer, if confirmed)
Fit with MSIT	Essay A	Operations experience → need for design-level depth

Tone: specific, modest, concrete. Each essay contains one real example, what you did, and what changed.

4. Essay drafts (DRAFT 1, for your rewrite)

[⏳ …] marks facts you must supply or confirm. Word counts exclude the bracketed notes.

Essay A: Why the MSIT, why CMU-Africa, and how I will use it (about 280 words)

Portal prompt: [paste exact prompt here]

At SantimPay, a fintech company in Addis Ababa, I work on the infrastructure behind digital payments: POS terminals in shops, QR payments and payment-gateway services used by Ethiopian banks and their customers. When a server or pipeline fails, a merchant cannot take a payment. That responsibility taught me how to keep systems running. It also showed me the limits of what I know.

Most of my work so far has been operational. I automate server configuration with Ansible, maintain deployment pipelines, and investigate incidents through monitoring tools. [⏳ one sentence: a concrete example, e.g. an incident you diagnosed, and what you changed afterwards.] Each time, I can fix the immediate problem, but I lack the depth in distributed systems, security engineering and architecture to redesign the system so the failure cannot recur.

My undergraduate record reflects that I grew into the field. After a weak start, my final-year semester averages were 3.05 and 3.35, and my strongest grades came in Compiler Design, Advanced Programming and my final-year project. [⏳ project topic, one clause.]

The CMU-Africa MSIT combines Carnegie Mellon's technical rigour with problems specific to African markets. [⏳ name 1–2 MSIT courses or concentrations from the official programme page and say why each matters to you.] I want to learn this alongside engineers from across the continent who face the same constraints: unreliable connectivity, growing transaction volumes, and the need for security that regulators and users can trust.

After the programme, I intend to return to Ethiopia's digital-payments sector and design infrastructure, not just maintain it: resilient, secure platforms that let smaller banks and merchants accept digital payments reliably.

Essay B: Professional journey and leadership (about 270 words)

Portal prompt: [paste exact prompt here]

I graduated in Computer Science from Debre Tabor University in July 2022 and joined SantimPay in [⏳ month 2022]. The company provides POS terminal management, QR merchant payments and school-payment services in partnership with Ethiopian banks.

My first role was [⏳ title]. I [⏳ 2 verified responsibilities]. Later, as [⏳ title], I [⏳ responsibility].

[⏳ LEADERSHIP EXAMPLE: fill only with a real event, using this structure]

- **Situation:** [e.g. a rollout of N POS terminals to merchants in X cities / a recurring outage]
- **My role:** [what you were responsible for; how many people you coordinated]
- **Action:** [the decisions you made]
- **Result:** [what changed, with a number only if you know it]
- **What I learned:** [one sentence]

[⏳ If you also worked at Kifiya, one or two sentences on the security work, using the dates confirmed by HR.]

Outside my job, I [⏳ only if confirmed: e.g. supported trainees as a co-trainer with Dereja in 2022, following up on their progress and preparing weekly reports for the training team].

These experiences taught me that reliable technology depends as much on coordination and communication as on code. I am at my best when I [⏳ honest trait, illustrated by the example above].

Essay C: Contribution to Ethiopia and Africa; future ambitions (about 250 words)

> **Portal prompt:** [paste exact prompt here]

In Ethiopia, many merchants and families are only now moving from cash to digital payments. I see the difference this makes when a terminal I helped configure lets a shop accept payment by card or QR code [⏳ keep only if true]. I also see what happens when systems fail: lost sales, lost trust, and customers returning to cash.

My long-term goal is to help build payment infrastructure in Ethiopia that is secure and dependable enough for that trust to grow. In the next five years after the MSIT, I aim to [⏳ a realistic goal, e.g. lead an infrastructure or platform-reliability team at an Ethiopian fintech or bank], and to apply architecture and security practices that are still rare in our market.

Giving back, for me, means sharing what I learn. [⏳ choose only real commitments, e.g.: I plan to mentor junior engineers in my company; to share practical DevOps material in Amharic; to support university students in Debre Tabor or Addis Ababa through talks or internships.]

The Mastercard Foundation's focus on leaders who return to their communities matches what I intend to do. A scholarship would allow me to study full-time without [⏳ honest financial situation, e.g. "the cost of tuition and living in Kigali, which my salary and family circumstances cannot cover"], and to return with skills that benefit others beyond my own career.

Optional Essay D: Academic record (use only if the prompt invites context; about 150 words)

My cumulative GPA of 2.62/4.00 does not show the trajectory of my studies. I completed my BSc through Debre Tabor University's extension programme over five academic years. My first years were weak, and I failed my first attempts at Probability & Statistics and Discrete Mathematics, which I later retook and passed. As I moved into core computer-science subjects my results improved: my final-year semester averages were 3.05 and 3.35, with A− grades in Compiler Design, Advanced Programming, Complexity Theory and both parts of my final-year project. Since graduating, I have applied that knowledge daily in production systems. I know mathematics is my weaker foundation, and I am [⏳ only if true: e.g. reviewing probability and discrete mathematics through ___] to be ready for graduate-level work.

5. Video essay preparation

- **Likely themes:** motivation, a challenge you overcame, leadership, what you would bring to the cohort. The actual format is shown in the portal.
- **Method:** 60–90 seconds per answer. Structure: point → example → reflection.

- **Practice:** record 3 takes. Check pace, eye contact and clear pronunciation. Keep sentences short.
- Full question bank: 12_INTERVIEW_PREPARATION/English_Test_and_Interview_Plan_v1.md.

6. Submission checklist

- ☐ Passport-spelling name used everywhere (DR-05)
- ☐ CV dates match the HR letters (DR-06, DR-07)
- ☐ Transcript uploaded (full; certified copy if requested)
- ☐ 3 essays plus the optional one, each ≤ 300 words, in your own words
- ☐ Video essay recorded
- ☐ 3 recommenders entered, and each has confirmed willingness
- ☐ English test plan: DET via the early-applicant arrangement, or a score already obtained
- ☐ Technical test completed when invited
- ☐ Financial-need information truthful and consistent
- ☐ **You** press submit; I never submit

7. Risks

Risk	Mitigation
Unresolved dates make the CV inconsistent with the references	Get the HR letters first
Mastercard Foundation need criterion	Be truthful; ask CMU-Africa about other aid if you are not selected
GPA below the typical admit	Strong technical test, specific essays, credible references
Speaking level (self-rated B1) for the video	Daily speaking practice (see the plan)